

While his family escaped on that occasion, Bakenga's father was eventually captured for ransom. "He was held for nine months. During that time, we had no idea whether he was dead or alive. When he eventually returned, he had lost nearly 40 kilos. As a child, I couldn't even recognise him for two months after he came back because he didn't look anything like my father," he says.

However, Bakenga's most traumatic memory wasn't the violence he or his family experienced, but an incident that symbolised the loss of his innocence. "At our home in Bukavu, I had a stuffed teddy bear in my room. I had to leave it behind when we were fleeing. One day, I was able to return home and ran back to my room to see my teddy bear again. But I found it riddled with bullets. I get goosebumps every time I remember this. It wasn't the most violent thing that happened to me, but it was the one that hurt me the most because it felt so personal," he says.

Bakenga says the few moments of happiness he experienced during those troubled days were found playing football. "Whenever we were in a place with some security, we kids would make a ball out of discarded plastic bags tied up with rope and play football with it," he recalls.

In 1998, Bakenga's mother, who worked for UNICEF, was evacuated along with the rest of his family back to Norway. He grew up facing his own challenges — he recalls playing football while parents of his opponents used racial slurs against him. While it hurt, Bakenga rationalises it. "At least no one was shooting at me," he says. His obvious talent in football eventually marked him out as one of the country's top prospects.

Unfulfilled life

His performances in the youth team of SK Nationalkameratene, and subsequently in the age group setups for Norway, attracted interest from Bayern Munich and Manchester City. Premier League club Chelsea invited him for trials and even made him an offer. However, Bakenga says



Face of hope: Bakenga's College, Namugunga, a school that now serves over 1,000 orphaned children in the Democratic Republic of Congo.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

he wanted to stay close to his family and ultimately chose to remain in Norway.

Even as his career blossomed in Norway and later in Europe, where he played in the Belgian Pro League (Cercle Brugge and Club Brugge) and the German second division (Eintracht Braunschweig), Bakenga says he felt a lack of fulfilment. "A lot of people think that when you escape a situation like mine, you should just focus on yourself. I was playing at a high level. I was making millions of dollars as a top-level player. Why should I care about Congo? But I felt a lot of guilt. I didn't understand why I was so lucky, while so many in Congo weren't. I wanted to do something about it. I couldn't live my life as if I was the only one who mattered. Football is important, but it has to be a way for me to help others," he recalls thinking.

Bakenga initially thought of setting up a football academy in Congo, but he realised he had no oversight of where the money would go. Then in 2017, his grandfather suggested he open a school instead. "There are people who can't afford to spend even a dollar a month for education. I felt this was a way to actually make a difference," he says.

When he initially set up College Namugunga, Bakenga expected to house around 300 students. He was

taken aback when nearly 1,000 showed up at its opening. "I couldn't turn them away. But I also couldn't pay for everything from just my earnings. That's when I decided I needed to set up a trust. I also got my family — my sisters and brothers — to help with running the school," he says. "Since 2017, we've helped this village a lot. We've also started self-help groups where we've set up farms for women to grow rice and potatoes, and fish farms so that mothers can make extra money. A portion of this goes to the school, so the children can eat for free," he says.

Bakenga has also used his name as a footballer to draw funds from sponsors. He convinced the Norwegian government to ship used furniture to his school and initiated a programme in which Norwegian schoolchildren could send their used school bags (all schoolchildren in Norway receive a new set at the start of the academic year).

For all the work he does, Bakenga admits things aren't always easy. "When I first started going back to contribute, I received death threats, and there were attempts to kidnap me because people knew I was making money playing football in Europe. So now, I don't make an announcement when I go back to Congo. I go quietly, do my work with the school, and then leave," he says.